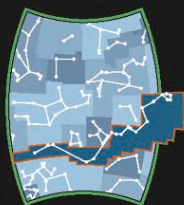


THE WATER SNAKE

Hydra



SIZE RANKING 1

BRIGHTEST STAR
Alphard (α) 2.0

GENITIVE Hydrae

ABBREVIATION Hya

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 P.M.
February–JuneFULLY VISIBLE
54°N–83°S

Hydra depicts the multiple-headed monster that fought and was killed by Hercules in the second of his labors (see panel, right). During the struggle, a crab joined forces with the Hydra but was crushed underfoot by Hercules; it was later commemorated as the constellation Cancer. Although the Hydra had nine heads, it is represented in the sky with a single head—presumably its immortal one.

The constellation is the largest of all 88 and stretches for more than a quarter of the way around the sky from its head, south of Cancer and just north of the celestial equator, to its tail in the Southern Hemisphere between Libra and Centaurus. Despite its size, there is little to mark out this constellation other than a group of six stars of modest brightness, which forms the head of the water snake.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

Hydra's brightest star is 2nd-magnitude Alphard, or Alpha (α) Hydrae. Alphard means "the solitary one," and this name reflects its position in an otherwise blank area of sky. This orange-colored giant is in fact the only star in the constellation brighter than magnitude 3.0. It is about 180 light-years away. Epsilon (ϵ) Hydrae is a close binary star with components of contrasting colors that can be

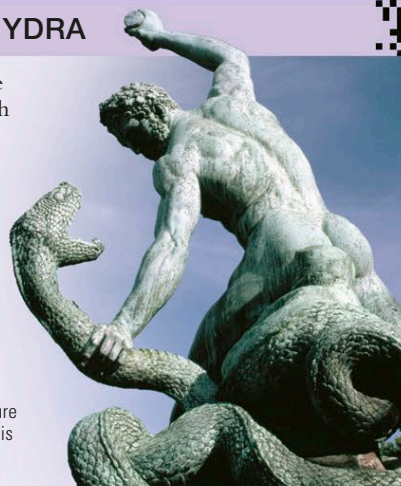
MYTHS AND STORIES

HERCULES AND THE HYDRA

The Hydra was a serpent with nine heads, one of them immortal, which lived in a swamp near the town of Lerna, emerging to ravage crops and cattle. As the second of his labors, Hercules was sent to kill the monster. He flushed it from its lair with flaming arrows and cut off each head in turn, ending with the immortal head, which he buried under a rock.

DEADLY BLOWS

Hercules battles with the Hydra in this sculpture by François-Joseph Bosio (1768–1845), which is exhibited in the Tuileries gardens, Paris.



LONG SERPENT

The Hydra's head, at the right in this photograph, lies south of Cancer while the tip of its tail lies far to the left, south of the stars of Libra.

divided with a telescope with an aperture of at least 3 in (75 mm) and high magnification. The yellow and blue component stars are of magnitude 3.4 and 6.7 and have an orbital period of nearly 600 years.

M48 is an open star cluster on the border with Monoceros. It lies nearly 2,000 light-years away. M48 is larger than a full moon and it is seen well through binoculars or a small telescope. It contrasts with the globular cluster M68 (see p.295), which resembles a fuzzy star when viewed through binoculars or a small telescope.

M83 is a spiral galaxy, toward the Hydra's tail, that lies about 15 million light-years away. Through a small telescope, it appears as an elongated glow, but a telescope of larger aperture will reveal its spiral structure and its noticeable central "bar," which may be similar to the bar that is thought to lie across the center of the Milky Way Galaxy.

The planetary nebula known as the Ghost of Jupiter, or NGC 3242, is to be found near the star Mu (μ) Hydrae, in the central part of Hydra's body.



THE GHOST OF JUPITER 𐄂

When viewed through a small telescope, the planetary nebula NGC 3242 appears as an ethereal, blue-green, elliptical glow about the size of the planet Jupiter, hence its popular name—the Ghost of Jupiter.

M83 𐄂

This magnificent face-on spiral galaxy is to be found lying on the border of Hydra and Centaurus. M83 has a central "bar" of stars and gas, and it is sometimes known as the Southern Pinwheel.

